A meeting between Prime Ministers P.V. Narasimha Rao and Goh Chok Tong of Singapore led to talks about a joint-venture airline between the two countries. Buoyed by the talks, Singapore Airlines (SIA) scouted for a suitable Indian partner. In 1995, the Tatas submitted a proposal with the Foreign Investment Promotion Board (FIPB) to set up a 40:60 equity partnership with SIA as the majority partner. But there was opposition to this partnership from existing operators such as Jet Airways, Damania, East-West and Air Sahara, as they believed that Tata–SIA would crowd them out because they had more Boeing aircraft than all of the others combined. Even Russi Mody, who was joint chairman of Air India and Indian Airlines at the time, was amongst their most vociferous opponents. Together, the opposition virtually killed Ratan's aviation plans.

In June 1996, a new coalition government came to power under H.D. Deve Gowda. In April 1997, this government amended the Civil Aviation Policy and barred foreign airlines from owning any equity in domestic air transport services.

But Ratan still harboured hope. He succeeded in reducing SIA's proposed stake in the airline to 50 per cent, and then to 40 per cent, which was equal to the combined foreign ownership in Jet Airways. But that changed nothing. There were too many roadblocks for him.

It was alleged that the aviation minister at the time, C.M. Ibrahim, was 'protecting Jet Airways' that had 'ambitious expansion plans'. Many years later, however, it came to light that Ratan's quest for entering the aviation industry was thwarted by an individual who had sought a payment of Rs 15 crore, which Ratan refused. It was a bold testament to his unflinching commitment to ethical ways even when it meant losing an opportunity to both fulfil his desire to get back Air India and resurrect JRD's dream.

Ratan's Persistence

Ratan is endowed with strategic patience. Despite the setback in the late 1990s, he persisted. A new chance to own at least a part of Air-India presented itself in early 2000 when the Vajpayee-led central government was looking to divest a 40 per cent stake in the airline.Bombay House reached out to SIA again, seeking technical expertise and partnership for the bid. After securing SIA's nod, in October 2000, the Tatas announced that it would lead a consortium with its foreign collaborator to buy the stake. It